

Chapter 67-4

Liang Shi saw a jumping-off-a-building scene in the drama and suddenly spoke up: "Although it's rude to interrupt you while watching TV, I still have something to say."

Xu Qingzhu pressed pause and raised an eyebrow: "What is it?"

"I remember you once said that Qi Jiao jumped off a building in her third year of middle school, right?" Liang Shi asked.

Xu Qingzhu nodded: "You're still investigating that matter with Qi Jiao?"

"Yes." Liang Shi said: "I saw her yesterday and found she still had wounds on her body. Rainbow said she often has those kinds of wounds on her body, so....."

She paused and didn't continue.

But Xu Qingzhu already understood.

Qi Jiao was still being abused, and she couldn't escape.

Although this was the Qi family's domestic affair, Liang Shi had also suffered this kind of abuse when she was young, and in her limited memories, that older sister had been good to her.

Even though she was very afraid and felt very wronged, she would still plead for young Liang Shi, would protect Liang Shi when her mother was hitting her, would urge Liang Shi to apologize and admit her mistakes, all just so she could suffer less beatings.

After hesitating, Liang Shi still played the conversation she had with Qiu Zimin today for Xu Qingzhu to hear.

Outside, the rain was falling harder and harder, with occasional thunderclaps.

It was clearly only a little past five o'clock, but the dark, oppressive clouds covered the sky, making it as gloomy as night.

The streetlights also came on earlier than usual.

Xu Qingzhu listened to the recording at double speed, and like Liang Shi, when she heard that line "So why would you go provoke a lunatic who would personally kill her own daughter," her expression showed surprise.

After listening to the end, she drew in a sharp breath of cold air, but the first thing she said was a conclusion: "She's planning to kick you out of the Liang family."

"I know." Liang Shi said: "I'm looking for a suitable place to live. Once I find one, I'll move out. I'll try to leave on my own before she kicks me out."

"Mm." Xu Qingzhu said: "I'll also have Cherry help me keep an eye out. When the time comes, let's move together."

She didn't take the opportunity to suggest separating or getting divorced, but instead planned to find another place that could accommodate both of them.

Liang Shi didn't bring up this matter either.

Her mind was now completely full of that sentence from Qiu Zimin. "So Yang Jiani personally killed her own daughter? Then who is the current Qi Jiao? She seems to know she's a replacement."

Xu Qingzhu nodded.

Because last time when Liang Shi went to find her, she had almost blurted out that Qi Jiao was already dead.

At that time, Liang Shi and Xu Qingzhu had speculated that she might have died in that jumping incident in the third year of middle school.

After all, from that point on, Qi Jiao had practically disappeared from public view.

But coincidentally..... Qiu Zimin said Yang Jiani herself had killed Qi Jiao.

Xu Qingzhu was also puzzled about one thing: "Is the current Qi Jiao someone who had plastic surgery? Had surgery to look like the original person. Then where is the original Qi Jiao's grave? According to Sister Ying, there's no way Yang Jiani wouldn't have made a grave for her daughter."

"That's also possible." Liang Shi said: "After all, now everyone thinks Qi Jiao is still alive."

"Can you tell where Qi Jiao had plastic surgery?" Xu Qingzhu asked.

Liang Shi thought about it, and based on her impressions from those she'd seen in the entertainment industry, answered: "Her nose seems to have been slightly augmented, she's also had her inner eye corners opened¹, and her mouth seems to have been plumped²."

"Then it wasn't major surgery." After Xu Qingzhu said this, she fell silent, her whole person sinking into a contemplative state.

Liang Shi also followed her train of thought, and a few minutes later, the two of them suddenly made eye contact and said in unison: "The orphanage!"

After speaking, the two of them smiled at the same time.

But their expressions quickly became grave again.

"Since the surgery wasn't extensive, it means this person's original appearance already resembled Qi Jiao somewhat. Plus, Qi Jiao's death should have been quite early, so the plastic surgery was done during adolescence." Liang Shi said: "Including after differentiation³, a person's appearance will still change, so no one knows that the current Qi Jiao isn't the original one."

"Right." Xu Qingzhu nodded: "It's impossible to encounter someone like this from normal people, so there are two scenarios."

"One is that this person's family is very poor, so poor that they would sell their daughter. She was bought by Yang Jiani to be a stand-in for her daughter. The other possibility is that Yang Jiani saw the current Qi Jiao at an orphanage. Because her daughter had passed away, she adopted this girl and transformed her into her own daughter."

More than ten years ago, identity information was far less complete than it is now.

The procedures for adopting a child from an orphanage weren't complicated either. If you had money, you could take a child away at any time.

So the latter possibility was the greatest.

After a moment of silence, Liang Shi said: "But there are still two scenarios now. One is that Yang Jiani first killed her daughter, then sought out a replacement in guilt and self-reproach, and found Qi Jiao. The other is that she felt her own daughter wasn't obedient enough, measured by her perverted standards, and then after seeing the current one, deliberately killed Qi Jiao and switched them....."

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If it was the latter, then the nature of this matter would be completely different.

How cruel would someone's heart have to be to do such a thing?

Liang Shi and Xu Qingzhu both fell silent, and the bubble tea in their hands had lost all its flavor.

After a while, Xu Qingzhu said: "I'll call Cherry."

Cherry's uncle had been doing charity work, sponsoring many orphanages and nursing homes, and Cherry had had a habit of regularly volunteering at orphanages and nursing homes since high school, so she might know more about these matters.

"Then I'll ask Sister Ying." Liang Shi said.

The two of them split up to take action.

Footnotes:

¹ Inner eye corners opened: Known as "开眼角" (kāi yǎnjiǎo) in Chinese, this is a cosmetic surgery procedure that removes skin at the inner corners of the eyes to make the eyes appear larger and more elongated. It's a common plastic surgery procedure in East Asia. There's also an outer eye corner procedure, but the inner corner procedure is more common.

² Plumped: Refers to "丰唇" (fēng chún) or lip augmentation/lip filler procedures to make lips appear fuller and more voluminous. This is typically done with injectable fillers.

³ Differentiation: Refers to the ABO dynamics concept where individuals "present" or develop into their designated secondary gender (Alpha, Beta, or Omega) during puberty. This is when their physical characteristics and pheromone production related to their ABO status fully manifest.